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Culture (OWC): [Luguru \(FN32\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1959-1960

Coverage Date: 1959 AD - 1960 AD

Place Coverage

Uluguru Mountains, Morogoro Region, Tanzania

Section Title(S): JOKING AND PRIVILEGED FAMILIARITY

In an early article, Eggan suggested in a preliminary interpretation that avoidance and joking were alternative solutions for resolving what could potentially be serious conflicts between kinsmen. Avoidance and respect were likely to occur between different generations, with joking and license permitted between members of the same generation where a conflict situation is inevitable. He suggested that because of the potential for conflict, jokes, satire, and sexual play could be expected to be greatest between siblings-in-law (Eggan 1937:75ff).

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The Luguru case does not support this interpretation in all respects. While a Luguru should show deference toward an elder, joking is permitted between all generations of watani, and the only avoidance observed is toward the mother-in-law. Admittedly, the potential for conflict is greatest between brothers-in-law, for with the avunculate, they both have a degree of control over the individual who is sister and wife. While the father must provide for and rear his children, the ultimate authority in the past has been the mother's brother. In spite of this, the Luguru do not single out in-laws as special targets for the more extreme forms of joking as suggested by Eggan, as in-laws need not be watani. If the greatest amount of joking does occur between watani who are affines, it is because they have more contact than others, and it does not differ in kind or in intensity from joking between watani who are not in-laws. Indeed, while mild joking may occur between siblings-in-law who are not watani, it is more of the type permitted among friends, and the extreme forms observed by watani would be considered bad taste.

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With the pattern of matrilocal residence, the joking permitted between watani is functional in reducing friction in the compound or hamlet. The Luguru are emphatic in regard to the desirability of marriage with a mtani and it is definitely a preferential form of marriage. For one thing, a man is likely to be marrying into the clan of his father or grandfather, but, in any case, he will

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have been joking with his wife's clan for years. The only individual he should avoid is his mother-in-law, a rather difficult task when he lives virtually next door to her. In practice, mother-in-law avoidance exists more in theory than in fact; actually, mother-in-law and son-in-law visit and talk, although he always treats her with respect and no joking is permitted between them.

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The position of the Luguru man in the hamlet is somewhat that of an outsider, and he must compete, to a degree, with his wife's kin for control of his children. If his in-laws are also his watani, his position is somewhat easier, for a relationship exists that takes no offence at criticism, insult, or disrespect. This tends to dissipate hostility and maintain harmony, for, as the Luguru frequently say: "If you marry a mtani you do not have trouble."

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